# HongSeok Kim

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**Citizenship**: Republic of Korea (F1)

## Education

**Iowa State University** Ames, USA
Ph.D. in Economics 2021 –
Advisor: Professor Juan Carlos Cordoba.

**Hanyang University** Seoul, Republic of Korea
M.A. in Economics and Finance 2021
B.A. in Economics and Finance 2019

## Research Interests

Macroeconomics, Public economics, Economics of Aging

## Working Paper

[3] **Precautionary Retirement**
HongSeok Kim
Abstract. We study how state-dependent risk of future Social Security benefit cuts changes the joint timing of claiming and retirement. When households attach a higher probability to a common future cut, they have an incentive to front-load protected payments by claiming earlier, but they also have a stronger incentive to self-insure by working longer and saving more. We develop a stylized mechanism and embed it in a life-cycle model disciplined by moments on employment, claiming, wealth, health, and earnings, together with Trustees-based measures of fiscal strain and depletion risk.

## Work in Progress

[2] **Social Security and the Distribution of Effective Retirement Incentives**
HongSeok Kim
Abstract. This paper asks how much does Social Security transform a common payroll-tax reform into different effective labor wedges across older workers, and how much do those wedge differences change retirement behavior? Standard policy analysis often treats payroll-tax changes as uniform incentive shifts, but for seniors the relevant object is not the statutory tax rate itself. It is the effective wedge on work after the benefit formula, claiming rules, and the Retirement Earnings Test are taken into account. Exploiting the 2011–2012 U.S. payroll-tax holiday with monthly SIPP data on workers ages 62–70, we find that retirement responses vary systematically with baseline tax exposure, claiming status, and the strength of marginal benefit accrual. Already-claimed workers respond most, consistent with facing a near-pure tax. A dynamic retirement model calibrated to pre-reform moments shows that the Retirement Earnings Test is a major barrier to pre-FRA work, and that benefit linkage sustains late-career employment. The policy incidence of payroll-tax reform for seniors depends on workers' institutional position within Social Security, not just on the statutory rate.

[1] **Ambiguity Aversion and Fertility Decisions**
HongSeok Kim

Abstract. This paper investigates how ambiguity aversion affects fertility decisions, considering the uncertainty surrounding the benefits of parenthood. We extend the Becker and Barro (1988) fertility model by incorporating ambiguity aversion to capture parents' decision-making process accurately. We assume that individuals care about their own and children's well-being (dynastic altruism) and face ambiguity about their children's future abilities (ambiguity aversion). Using a multiple priors utility framework, we model parents' preferences as maximizing their minimum expected utility of descendants, focusing on the worst-case scenario for their child's ability. Our findings suggest that more ambiguity-averse parents tend to have fewer children, as they emphasize the lowest possible outcome. This insight helps explain declining fertility rates and rising childlessness in developed countries, as individuals prioritize predictable outcomes over uncertain returns of parenthood.

## Fellowships

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| Graduate Student Workshop Fellowship, Western Economic Association International | 2026 |
| Summer Teaching Assistantship, Iowa State University | 2025 |
| Most Engaging Presentation Award, EGSA, Iowa State University | 2025 |
| Best Discussant Award, EGSA, Iowa State University | 2025 |
| Research Travel Grant ($750) × 4, Iowa State University | 2023–2025 |
| Brain Korea 21 Plus Scholarship, Hanyang University | 2020–2021 |
| Academic Scholarship HY-IN Graduate School Scholarship, Hanyang University | 2020 |
| Academic Fellowship Korea Student Aid Foundation Fellowship | 2019 |
| Graduation Award, Hanyang University | 2019 |

## Seminar & Conference

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| North American Summer Meeting (NASM), Emory University† | 2026 |
| Asia Meeting of the Econometric Society, East & Southeast Asia (AMES), Vietnam† | 2026 |
| 101th Western Economic Association International† | 2026 |
| Workshop on AI and Machine Learning for Economists, Iowa State University | 2025 |
| Southern Economic Association, Washington D.C | 2025 |
| 19th Economics Graduate Student Conference, Washington University in St. Louis | 2024 |
| Midwest Macro Meetings, Purdue University | 2024 |
| Macro Reading Group, Iowa State University | 2024 |
| Midwest Economic Association, Chicago | 2023 |

†Scheduled.

## Academic Experience

**Sole Instructor** — Iowa State University

ECON 1020: Principles of Macroeconomics (*Eval: 4.36/5.0*) — Summer, 2025

**Recitation Instructor – Graduate** — Iowa State University

ECON 6020: Macroeconomic Analysis (Ph.D. Core, *Eval: 5.0/5.0*) — 2025F

ECON 6030: Advanced Microeconomics - Game Theory (Ph.D. Core, *Eval: 4.67/5.0*) — 2023S

ECON 6040: Advanced Macroeconomics Analysis (Ph.D. Core, *Eval: 5.0/5.0*) — 2024S, 2025S, 2026S

ECON 5710: Intermediate Econometrics (Masters) — 2026S

**Teaching Assistant/Lab Instructor – Undergraduate** — Iowa State University

ECON 1010: Principles of Microeconomics — 2021, 2023, 2024

ECON 1020: Principles of Macroeconomics — 2022, 2023, 2024, 2025

ECON 3020: Intermediate Macroeconomics (*Eval: 5.0/5.0*) — 2025

ECON 3710: Introduction to Econometrics (*Eval: 4.29/5.0*) — 2021

## Academic Service

**Discussions**

"Urbanicity and Fertility: Evidence from Refugees to Canada",
– Midwest Economics Association Meetings, Chicago — 2024

**Guest Lecture**

ECON3270 (Economics of Discrimination)
– Quantity-Quality Trade-off of Gary Becker's Model — 2025

**Other Service**

Economic Help Room Services for the Undergraduates — 2021, 2023